right or wrong, and they weren't always right. I decided I had to take my career into my own hands—and came up with a plan to marry my new job in Hollywood with my old love for football.

I was fascinated with the life story of Knute Rockne, the legendary Norwegian-born coach at Notre Dame who died in a plane crash in 1931 after revolutionizing the game of football.

Over lunch in the Warner Brothers commissary, I began talking up the idea of a movie based on his life and asked some of our writers for pointers on how to write a screenplay about him. I began working on a script and over lunch one day suggested to Pat O'Brien, a fellow Irishman who had become a good friend, that he'd make the perfect Rockne.

Of course, I'd already cast my own part in the movie: George Gipp, who casually wandered onto Rockne's practice field one day and as his greatest star became almost as legendary as the coach himself before dying two weeks after his final game.

As I continued my work on a screenplay, I never thought about getting paid for it. My reward was the part of George Gipp—the immortal Gipper. Then one day I saw an article in *Variety:* Warner Brothers was going to make a movie based on the life of Knute Rockne starring Pat O'Brien.

When I asked some friends how this had happened they told me I talked too much, that it was a good idea so Warners bought the rights to Rockne's life story. But then they told me Warners had already tested ten actors for the part of Gipp. I ran all the way to the producer's office and asked for a shot at the role. He turned me down because he said I didn't look like the greatest football player of our time. "You mean Gipp has to weigh about two hundred pounds?" I asked. "Would it surprise you that I'm five pounds *heavier* than George Gipp was when he played at Notre Dame?"